

DIRT 3™

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"Codemasters took *Dirt 2*, a high perfect game, and made it better." Here's a detailed look at what makes *Dirt 3* the best rally-based racing simulation since *Dirt 2*.

Beautiful yet realistic, hardcore yet playable, there isn't an adjective that you can use for *Dirt 3* that hasn't already been used for *Dirt 2*, except for perhaps, 'complete.' Don't get me wrong, *Dirt 2*, as a standalone title was not incomplete, however, some of the most demanding and greedy of us felt that snow and rain were environmental conditions that shouldn't have been left out. Night driving was present earlier, but only in Rally Cross modes. Split-screen racing was another demand that players the world over with two controllers wanted. The even greedier bunch amongst us asked for that one extra discipline apart from Rally, Rally Cross, Raid, Landrush, Gatecrasher, Domina-

tion and Last Man Standing; one more to round out the X-Games styled section of *Dirt 2* – the Gymkhana stunt section.

Codemasters listened, and took nearly two years to deliver all these additions, as well as other new challenge-based gameplay modes such as Capture the Flag and Tag, which take place in the Battersea compound. The Gymkhana mode and the Battersea challenges inject some variety into the game, but may not be everyone's cup of tea. However, once you overcome them, you'll feel quite satisfied.

Another major change in *Dirt 3* is that one no longer needs XP to unlock cars. Your garage consists of the cars you've unlocked in the campaign, and you can use these in the Single Player events. While some critics find this defeats the racing game collector's instinct, and tends to leave many cars unused and untried, I differ. There was never a shortage of money in *Dirt 2* to buy whichever cars and kits you wanted at any time, so it barely makes a difference here – except for the



fact that you can't always drive your favourite multi-discipline/track car.

What's also new is the ability to upload 30-second clips of your racing replay to YouTube. You still can't save entire replays even locally however.

Graphically, *Dirt 3* is highly detailed, and can give even reasonably high-end DX11 graphics cards a run for their money at high resolutions. Lighting is noticeably better across conditions and times of day, shadows and reflections are realistic, and the overall attention to detail given to the scenery and the track is incredible to behold. While some critics complain about the lack of 'terrain deformation' in the game, I was too busy looking ahead and enjoying the world rush by at high speed to care whether my tires made an impression in the snow behind me, or my last crash demolished the snow bank. Driving while it's raining or snowing is quite something to behold, with drops and flakes flying by, twisting and turning with you on turns. Rain drops splattering on the windshield in the cockpit view however could have been a little more extravagant, for as it stands now, they're barely distracting – too easy.

As a simulation, *Dirt 3* is not very forgiving in Advanced mode with all assists turned

off; however, it comes with five flashbacks (at the cost of XP earned in the race), regardless of the difficulty setting – a training wheel for those of us who opted for no training wheels. New assists like dynamic racing line are also available now. Controls can be easily adjusted at any point in the race. As with *Dirt 2*, a quick tuning menu called Service Area is available before every race, helping you fine-tune your ride for every track and condition – as useful as always. **A**

Verdict: Codemasters took *Dirt 2*, a perfect game, and made it better.

Pros

- Beautiful graphics
- Great handling
- Variety of gameplay modes

Cons

- Steep learning curve

Details

GENRE: Racing, Arcade
STUDIO: Codemasters Racing Studio
PUBLISHER: Codemasters, Zapak Games
***PLATFORMS:** PC (MS Windows), PlayStation 3, Xbox 360

PRICE:

PC (MS WINDOWS): ₹699/-
PLAYSTATION 3, XBOX 360: ₹2,499/-

*REVIEWED ON PC

MSI TwinFrozr II HD 5830 - Phenom II X4 B50 @ 3.1GHz - 4GB DDR3 @ 1333MHz

